



Instructor Guide

Lesson Metadata

Field	Detail
Path	Digital Independence Path
Course	Course 18: Professional Presence & Opportunity Building
Lesson	Lesson 6: Networking and Professional Communication
Age range	15-18
Format	Live, instructor-led (video conference), 60 minutes
Tools used	LinkedIn (16+ only; portfolio site/PDF resume as alternative for under-16 or those who opt out), Google Docs, Email
Prerequisites	Lesson 1-5 of Course 18 (student has a draft resume/portfolio and understands online safety basics from the Digital Independence Path's earlier privacy lessons)
Group size	Best with 6-16 students to allow discussion and message review
Materials students need	A laptop/device, an existing email account, access to Google Docs, list of 3-5 real people they already know (teacher, family friend, coach, past instructor, relative)

Lesson Overview

This lesson reframes "networking" for teenagers away from the anxiety-inducing, transactional image many of them have absorbed (cold LinkedIn messages, "hustle culture" content, mass outreach). Instead, students learn that professional networking at this age is about **nurturing real relationships they already have** — teachers, coaches, family friends, alumni of their school, instructors from Lumexa or other programs — and communicating with them respectfully and clearly.

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

1. Explain the difference between networking and cold/mass messaging strangers.
2. Identify 3-5 real, existing contacts appropriate for professional outreach.
3. Write a polite, well-structured introduction or outreach message using a repeatable formula.
4. Apply professional communication etiquette (tone, timing, follow-up, gratitude) across email, Google Docs comments, and LinkedIn.

5. State the lesson's safety norms from memory and apply them to their own outreach plan.

Safety Framing (Non-Negotiable — Read Before Class)

This lesson is about **existing, known, real-world connections** — not meeting or messaging strangers. Instructors must not let the lesson drift into "add strangers on LinkedIn to grow your network" territory. Reinforce constantly:

- Every outreach message a student plans to send should be **known to a trusted adult** (parent, guardian, or the instructor) before or as it is sent.
- Students **never** arrange to meet anyone from online outreach in person alone. If an outreach contact suggests meeting, a trusted adult is involved in planning it (and in practice, at this age, almost all "networking" contact stays in writing/video, not in-person solo meetings).
- LinkedIn has a **16+ minimum age**. Under 16, or any student/family who prefers not to use LinkedIn, uses the portfolio-first alternative (a personal portfolio site or PDF one-pager + email) instead. Do not pressure any student to create a LinkedIn account.
- Students should never share home address, school schedule/location details, financial information, or passwords in any outreach message.
- If any contact's reply ever feels off, pushy, overly personal, or makes a student uncomfortable, the instruction is simple: **stop responding and tell a trusted adult immediately**. This is not a failure on the student's part — it is the correct, expected action.

Prep Before Class

- Review each student's Course 18 portfolio/resume draft from prior lessons so you can reference it during the demo.
- Have the fictional demo exchange (below) open and ready to screen-share.
- Confirm which students have parental permission for LinkedIn (16+) vs. who will use the portfolio-first path — do not assume.
- Open a blank Google Doc to model live message-drafting.

Teaching Sequence

1. Warm-Open & Reframe (5 min)

Ask: "When you hear the word 'networking,' what comes to mind?" Expect answers like "awkward," "asking strangers for jobs," "LinkedIn spam," "used-car-salesman energy." Validate that this reaction is common and reasonable — because most of what teens see modeled online *is* that.

Reframe: "Real networking, especially at your age, is just **staying in touch with people who already know you, in a way that's clear and respectful**. It's not messaging 500 strangers. It's writing one thoughtful message to your old robotics coach."

2. Networking vs. Mass Cold-Messaging (8 min)

Present the contrast directly (write on shared screen or slide):

Networking (what we do)	Mass cold-messaging (what we don't do)
Reaching out to someone who already knows you or is one warm introduction away	Messaging strangers you have no connection to, hoping one responds
One thoughtful, specific message	Copy-pasting the same generic message to dozens of people
A real reason tied to a shared context ("you taught my Intro to Python class")	No context, just "let's connect"
No immediate ask, or a small, specific, low-pressure ask	Asking a stranger for a job/favor immediately
Trusted adult is aware	No one else knows the outreach is happening

Talking point: "Quality over quantity isn't just etiquette — it's what actually works. One genuine message to your former teacher who remembers you will get a warmer, more useful reply than fifty generic messages to strangers who don't know you and have no reason to respond."

3. Live Demo: A Polite Introduction Message (12 min)

Screen-share a Google Doc. Build the message live, narrating each choice, using the fictional example below (also in the Student Lesson).

Scenario: Jordan R., 17, wants to reach back out to Ms. Alvarez, who taught Jordan's sophomore-year intro coding elective, to ask a small, specific question about a summer program.

Demo message (write it live, line by line, narrating why):

Subject: Question from a former student — Jordan R.

Hi Ms. Alvarez,

I hope your school year is off to a good start! This is Jordan Reyes — I was in your Intro to Coding elective sophomore year (I sat near the front, and did the maze-solving robot project).

I'm applying to a summer coding program this year and remembered how much I enjoyed your class. Would you be open to answering one or two quick questions about how you got started in tech, whenever you have a few minutes? No pressure at all if you're busy — I completely understand.

Thank you for considering it, and I hope you're doing well!

Best, Jordan Reyes

Narrate the structure as you go: **who you are + shared context** → **genuine reason for reaching out** → **small, specific, low-pressure ask** → **gracious close** → **full name**. Point out what's absent: no attachment of personal documents yet, no request for a job, no urgency/pressure language, no personal contact info beyond what's needed.

Then show a **sample reply** and model a **thank-you follow-up** (see Student Lesson worked example) so students see the full loop, not just the opening message.

4. Etiquette Across Tools (8 min)

Briefly cover tool-specific norms:

- **Email:** Clear subject line, greeting, sign-off with full name, check spelling/tone before sending, reply within a few days if you receive a reply.
- **Google Docs (comments/shared drafts):** When commenting on a shared doc (e.g., a mentor reviewing your resume), keep comments specific and gracious ("Thanks for catching that — fixed!"), don't @-mention people repeatedly, resolve comments once addressed.
- **LinkedIn (16+ only):** Always send a connection request with a short personal note (never blank), use real name and a professional-looking photo or none at all, keep the profile portfolio-first (projects, skills) rather than treating it like a general social feed.
- **Portfolio-first alternative (under 16 / opt-out):** A one-page site or PDF resume + email is fully equivalent for this lesson's purposes — reassure students this is not a lesser option.

5. Guided Activity Launch (15 min)

Students open their own Google Doc (from the Worksheet) and: 1. List 3-5 real people from their existing network. 2. Pick one. 3. Draft one real introduction/outreach message using the formula. 4. Note how/when they'll tell a trusted adult about this outreach (before sending, ideally).

Circulate (or use breakout rooms if virtual) to review drafts one-on-one. Do **not** let students send the message during class — the message should go home for trusted-adult review first, unless a parent/guardian is present and reviewing live.

6. Discussion Questions (Weave in during activity or close, ~7 min total)

- "Why might a short, specific message get a better response than a long, vague one?"
- "What's the difference between asking someone to 'grab coffee and pick their brain' and asking one clear question?"
- "If someone you reached out to never replies, what should you do? What should you *not* do?" (Answer: it's fine, people are busy; don't send repeated follow-ups or take it personally; one polite follow-up after 1-2 weeks is the max.)
- "Why does a trusted adult need to know about this kind of outreach, even though it feels like 'just an email'?"

7. Lesson Close (5 min)

Recap the three big ideas: (1) networking = nurturing real, existing relationships, not mass-messaging strangers; (2) a good message is short, specific, and low-pressure; (3) a trusted adult is always in the loop on outreach. Preview that Lesson 7 will build on this by covering how to follow up and keep in touch over time.

Common Misconceptions to Correct

- **"Networking means messaging as many people as possible."** Correct: one genuine message beats dozens of generic ones; quality and relevance matter far more than volume.
- **"I need to ask for something big right away (a job, an internship, a recommendation)."** Correct: the first message should have a small, low-pressure ask, or no ask at all beyond reconnecting — trust and relationships are built over multiple respectful interactions, not one transactional request.
- **"If I don't have a 'real' professional connection, I have no one to reach out to."** Correct: teachers, coaches, relatives' colleagues, past instructors, and school alumni all count as real network contacts at this age.
- **"Not hearing back means I did something wrong."** Correct: busy adults often don't reply immediately or at all; it is not personal and does not require an apology-toned follow-up.

Anticipated Student Difficulties & Troubleshooting

Difficulty	Instructor Response
Student can't think of anyone to list	Prompt with categories: teachers/coaches, family friends in any job, relatives, past camp/program instructors, school alumni they've met. Everyone has at least 2-3.
Message drafts are too long/rambling	Point back to the formula; ask "what's the one sentence version of your context, and the one sentence version of your ask?"
Student wants to ask for something big (e.g., a job) right away	Redirect gently: "Let's make the first message just about reconnecting or one small question — bigger asks come later, after there's a relationship again."
Student is anxious about "bothering" someone	Normalize: most adults are flattered when a former student reaches out respectfully; a polite, brief message is never a bother.
Student wants to add a stranger found online because they "seem successful"	Firmly redirect: this lesson is only about real, existing connections; cold-adding strangers is explicitly out of scope and discouraged.
Under-16 student feels excluded by LinkedIn examples	Reaffirm the portfolio-first path is equal in value; use their existing portfolio/PDF resume for the same exercise.

How to Review Student Work

Check each drafted message for: - [] Names a real, specific person the student actually knows (not a stranger or invented person). - [] States shared context clearly in the first 1-2 sentences. - [] Has a genuine, low-pressure reason for the message. - [] Ask (if any) is small and specific, not vague or large. - [] Tone is warm, respectful, and appropriately brief (roughly 80-150 words). - [] No personal safety information included (address, schedule, passwords, financial info). - [] Student has identified a trusted adult and a plan to loop them in before sending.

Give feedback as a comment directly on the student's Google Doc so they practice receiving professional-style feedback in the same tool they'll use for real mentor review later in the course.

Assessment Tie-In

This lesson's knowledge checks and worksheet feed the Course 18 portfolio project rubric criterion "Professional Communication," which is scored in the course capstone in Lesson 10.